

The Cessation of Kamma

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1 The *Kammanirodha Sutta*

In the *kammanirodha sutta* (SN 35.146), the Buddha formulates the four noble truths in terms of kamma as follows:

O bhikkhus, I will teach you new and old kamma, the cessation of kamma, and the path leading to the cessation of kamma. Listen to that and do mind it well, I will speak.”

And what, O bhikkhus, is old kamma? The eye, O bhikkhus, is old kamma, especially conditioned, especially intended, to be seen as something to be felt. The ear.... The nose.... The tongue.... The body.... The mind, O bhikkhus, is old kamma, especially conditioned, especially intended, to be seen as something to be felt. This, O bhikkhus, is called old kamma.

And what, O bhikkhus, is new kamma? O bhikkhus, whatever action is done by body, speech, or mind in the present [life]. This, O bhikkhus, is called new kamma.

And what, O bhikkhus, is the cessation of kamma? [That] which touches liberation through the cessation of bodily action, verbal action and mental action. This, O bhikkhus, is called the cessation of kamma.

“And what, O bhikkhus, is the path leading to the cessation of kamma? It is just this noble eightfold path, that is – right view, right intention, right speech, right action, right livelihood, right effort, right mindfulness, right samadhi. This, O bhikkhus, is called the path leading to the cessation of kamma.

–SN 35.146

So then, old kamma pertains to kamma done and accumulated in past lives to be felt via the six senses. New kamma pertains to the accumulation of kamma being done in this present life. The cessation of kamma pertains to both old and new kamma and is defined as that which touches liberation through the cessation of bodily, verbal and mental action. The path leading to the cessation of kamma is just this noble eight-fold path.

The definitions of old kamma, new kamma and the path leading to the cessation of kamma are all quite clear in this *sutta*. The definition of the cessation of kamma (*kammanirodha*), however, needs more clarification.

2 The Cessation of Kamma

The Buddha makes a distinction between two types of kamma in the *paṭhamanidāna sutta* (AN 3.111), namely, kamma that leads to the origination of kamma, which is any kamma born of greed, hatred or delusion; and kamma that leads to the cessation of kamma, which is any kamma born of non-greed, non-hatred or non-delusion.

He states in the *nidāna sutta* (AN 3.34): “Whatever kamma is born of greed, hatred or delusion, wherever self-begetting is actualized, it

is there that the kamma ripens. Wherever that kamma ripens, it is there that the results are felt, either in this life or in the [next] arising or in some other [arisings] in succession.”

“Whatever kamma is born of non-greed, non-hatred or non-delusion, that kamma is abandoned when greed, hatred and delusion are eliminated. It is cut off at the root, made like palm stump, obliterated so that it is no longer subject to future arising.”

Since the Buddha’s definition of the cessation of kamma refers to both the cessation of old kamma and the cessation of new kamma, we first look at how the cessation of old kamma comes about.

2.1 Cessation of Old Kamma

In the *sancetana sutta* (AN 10.217), the Buddha makes it clear that without experiencing all kamma accumulated in past lives, the attainment of arahantship is not possible:

“I, O bhikkhus, do not say that [there is] the termination of intentional kamma accumulated in past [lives] without having experienced [it], and that is in this [present] life, or in the [next] arising or in some other [arisings] in succession. But still I, O bhikkhus, do not say [there is] the making of an end of suffering without having experienced intentional kamma accumulated in past [lives].”

–AN 10.217

Since all kamma that lead to the cessation of kamma get destroyed after they have served their purpose of eliminating greed, hatred and delusion as stated in the *nidāna sutta* (AN 3.34), the Buddha’s declaration can be paraphrased as follows: Without experiencing all kamma born of greed, hatred or delusion accumulated in past lives, the attainment of arahantship is not possible.

This declaration presents a problem for the commentators of the *dharmapada* verses and the *jātaka* verses. The commentator of the *dharmapada* verses claim that the venerable Mahāmoggallāna’s death was caused by his past life evil kamma of killing his parents. On

the other hand, the commentator of the *jātaka* verses claim that the venerable Mahāmoggallāna’s death was caused by his past life evil kamma of intending to kill his parents but changing his mind later and not carrying through with his intentions (see [the venerable Anandajoti’s translation of the dhammapada verses commentaries](#)). The commentators’ claim that the venerable Mahāmoggallāna had not terminated all the evil kamma accumulated in his past lives at the time of his death implies that the venerable Mahāmoggallāna could not have been an arahant. Since it cannot be denied that the venerable Mahāmoggallāna was an arahant, the *Anguttāra Nikāya* commentator asserts that the Buddha’s declaration should not be interpreted as stated. The venerable Bhikkhu Bodhi translates the commentator’s interpretation in his notes on the Buddha’s declaration as follows:

Mp explains the text’s statement as having an implicit meaning: “This is intended to show that as long as *saṃsāra* continues, if there is kamma that has acquired the capacity to ripen (*paṭiladdhaviṭṭhārahakamma*) ‘there is no place on earth where one might escape an evil deed’” (the citation, *na vijjati so jagatippadeso, yatthaṭṭhito mucceyya pāpakammā*, is from [Dhp 127])

–Venerable Bhikkhu Bodhi’s notes on AN 10.217

The full verses [Dhp 127-128] that the *Anguttāra Nikāya* commentator eluded to in his explanation are as follows:

Neither in the air, nor the middle of the ocean,
nor going into an open cleft in a mountain; 127
a place in the world does not exist,
where staying one could be released from evil
kamma.

Neither in the air, nor the middle of the ocean,
nor going into an open cleft in a mountain, 128
a place in the world does not exist,
where staying one is not overpowered by death.

–Dhp 127-128

Here, the Buddha is saying that just as one who is born cannot escape death, so too one who has done evil kamma cannot escape its results.

This is stated in another way in the *pāṭibhoga sutta* (AN 4.182), where the Buddha declares that just as for what is liable to death, there is neither a samana nor brahmana nor Deva nor Mara nor Brahma nor anyone in the world who can guarantee that it will not die, so too for those evil kamma which are defiling, renewing a being, dreadful, ripening in suffering, bound up with future birth, old age and death, there is neither a samana nor brahmana nor Deva nor Mara nor Brahma nor anyone in the world who can guarantee that their results will not actualize.

Thus, even though the Buddha is comparing the inescapability of accumulated evil kamma to the inescapability of death, the commentator wants us to believe that when the Buddha says “accumulated past [life] kamma (*kammānaṃ katānaṃ upacitānaṃ*, lit. accumulated kamma done)”, he really means to say “only kamma that has acquired the capacity to ripen,” meaning that if the kamma has not acquired the capacity to ripen, then one can still become an arahant and escape its results, rendering it an ownerless kamma (*ahosikamma*) never to ripen, since the arahant cannot be born again.

If we accept the commentator’s interpretation and amend the Buddha’s declaration accordingly, then the Buddha’s declaration would read:

nāhaṃ bhikkhave sañcetanikānaṃ paṭiladdhavipākārahakam-
mānaṃ appaṭisaṃviditvā vyantībhāvaṃ vadāmi. tañca
kho diṭṭhe va dhamme upapajje vā apare vā pariyāye. na
tve vāhaṃ bhikkhave sañcetanikānaṃ paṭiladdhavipākāra-
hakammānaṃ appaṭisaṃviditvā dukkhassantakiriyaṃ vadāmi.

It translates as:

I, O bhikkhus, do not say that [there is] the termination of intentional kamma that has acquired the capacity to ripen without having experienced [it], and that is in this life, or in the [next] arising or in some other [arisings] in

succession. But still I, O bhikkhus, do not say [there is] the making of an end of suffering without having experienced intentional kamma that has acquired the capacity to ripen.”

By the commentator’s own definition, once an intentional kamma accumulated in past lives *has acquired* the capacity to ripen, there is no escape from experiencing its results in the present, since *has acquired* pertains to the present. If its results are not experienced in the present, then it has not yet acquired the capacity to ripen and so the commentator speaking rightly would say, it *will acquire* the capacity to ripen, since *will acquire* pertains to the future. So if an intentional kamma accumulated in past lives *has acquired* the capacity to ripen, then there is no longer any ambiguity about the timing of its ripening, since the owner cannot escape experiencing its results in the present. Thus, if the Buddha really means to say there is no making of an end of suffering without having experienced intentional kamma accumulated in past lives that has acquired the capacity to ripen in the present, then there would be no need for the Buddha to state the possibility of that kamma ripening in the next [arising] or some other [arisings] in succession since its experiencing in the present cannot be escaped. As the Buddha states in the *niruttipatha sutta* (SN 22.62), wise ascetics and brahmins do not mix up the past, the future and the present in their declarations as proposed by the *Anguttāra Nikāya* commentator.

Another argument brought forth by the proponents of *ahosikamma*, is that it is impossible to experience all the evil kamma accumulated in past lives because this *samsāra* has no known beginning, and so all beings must have accumulated an infinite number of evil kamma in their past lives, which they claim should take an infinite number of lives to experience its results, making the attainment of arahantship impossible if the Buddha’s declaration is to be interpreted as stated. But although the Buddha states that the understanding of the ripening of kamma is only within the powers of the Buddhas, he provides some guidelines for ruling out any interpretation of the ripening of kamma which would make living the life of purity for rightly making an end to suffering impossible, as wrong interpretation in the *loṇaphala sutta* (AN 3.100):

Whoever, O bhikkhus, might say thus: “In which ever way that a person creates a kamma, in just that way he

experiences.” That being so, O bhikkhus, there is not the living of the life of purity and an opportunity for rightly making an end of suffering is not evident.

But whoever, O bhikkhus, might say thus: “In which ever way to be felt that a person creates a kamma, in just that way he feels the results.” That being so, O bhikkhus, there is the living of the life of purity and an opportunity for rightly making an end of suffering is evident.

—AN 3.100

Thus, such naive interpretations of the workings of kamma which negates the living of the life of purity for rightly making an end to suffering, can be ruled out as wrong interpretations.

In the *mahāpuṇṇama sutta* (MN 109) the Buddha proclaims the *saṅkhāra* appropriable *khandha* to be any type of *saṅkhāra* whatsoever, whether past, future or present, internal or external, gross or subtle, inferior or superior, far or near, all sankharas and anything pertaining to sankharas such as kamma, are included in the *saṅkhāra* appropriable *khandha*, whether finite or infinite is irrelevant. As the Buddha declares in the *nidāna sutta* verses (AN 3.34), the amount of kamma done in past lives born of greed, hatred and delusion, whether little or much is inconsequential. If it is to be experienced in hell, the animal womb or the realm of ghosts, then it is all to be felt right here in this life as no other ground exists for their fruition for one who has given rise to noble knowledge.

To see how all accumulated kamma are included in the *saṅkhāra* appropriable *khandha*, the Buddha defines kamma as *cetanā* in the *nibbedhika sutta* (AN 6.63), saying “It is intention (*cetanā*), O bhikkhus, that I call kamma. For having intended, one acts by body, speech, or mind”.

In the *upādānapariṇipavatta sutta* (SN 22.56), the Buddha defines the *saṅkhārā* appropriable *khandha* as *cetanā*:

“And what, O bhikkhus, are sankharas? There are these six classes of intention — intention for forms, intention for sounds, intention for aromas, intention for tastes, intention for tangibles, intention for dhammas. These, O bhikkhus, are called sankharas.”

–SN 22.56

In the *khajjaniya sutta* (SN 22.79), the Buddha explains why sankharas are called sankharas as follows:

And why, O bhikkhus, do you call them sankharas? ‘They activate activities,’ O bhikkhus, therefore they are called sankharas.

And what are the activities that they activate? ‘They activate the activity of form as form; they activate the activity of feeling as feeling; they activate the activity of perception as perception; they activate the activity of sankharas as sankharas; they activate the activity of consciousness as consciousness’. ‘They activate activities,’ O bhikkhus, therefore they are called sankharas.

–SN 22.79

From this definition, since sankharas activate the *saṅkhārā* appropriate *khandha* themselves, we see that sankharas lead to origination of sankharas. But what about the other four *saṅkhatā* (form, feeling, perception and consciousness) that sankharas activate? These also being appropriate khandhas, we know that they are *anicca*, *saṅkhata*, *paṭicca samuppannam*, and since all sankharas are *anicca* (*sabbe saṅkhārā anicca*), these four *saṅkhatā* are also sankharas, thus we can conclude that sankharas lead to origination of sankharas.

But do there exist sankharas that lead to the cessation of sankharas? From *aggappasādā sutta* (AN 4.34), the Buddha declares:

“To whatever extent there are dhammas that are conditioned, the noble eightfold path is declared the foremost among them.”

–AN 4.34

We know that the noble eightfold path leads to the stilling of all sankharas (*sabbasaṅkhārasamatho*), and since the noble eightfold path is *saṅkhatā*, and *saṅkhatā* are sankharas, thus sankharas also lead to the cessation of sankharas.

So we can conclude that, sankharas either lead to the origination of sankharas or to the cessation of sankharas.

The question may arise as to whether there could be sankharas that neither lead to origination of sankharas nor to the cessation of sankharas. The answer is that there cannot be, as such sankharas will be *asaṅkhata* (*nibbāna*), a self-contradiction.

Thus, if kamma is *cetanā* and *cetanā* is a type of *saṅkhārā*, and sankharas have only two possibilities, either leading to the origination of sankharas or to the cessation of sankharas, then we must conclude that kamma, being a type of sankharas can only have two possibilities as well, either leading to the origination of kamma or to the cessation of kamma.

This is confirmed in the *paṭhamanidāna sutta* (AN 3.111) as quoted above, where the Buddha states that any action born of greed, hatred or delusion is designated as kamma that leads to the origination of kamma (*kammaṃ kammāsamudayāya saṃvattati*), whereas any action born of non-greed, non-hatred or non-delusion is designated as kamma that leads to the cessation of kamma (*kammaṃ kammanirodhāya saṃvattati*). So from this *sutta*, we find only two possibilities for kamma as well: kamma either leads to the origination of kamma or leads to the cessation of kamma. Thus, kamma is a subset of the *saṅkhāra* appropriable *khandha*, and so whether the amount of kamma done in the past in this long *saṃsāra* without discoverable beginning is infinite or finite, it cannot escape depletion when the *saṅkhāra* appropriable *khandha* goes to depletion. Even *saṃsāra* itself does not lie outside of the five appropriable *khandhas*, even though it has no known beginning.

The notion of *ahosikamma* is a popular fallacy among commentators and scholars alike. It asserts that the owner of evil kamma can escape its results and render that kamma ownerless, never to ripen. It comes about because for beings subject to the results of evil kamma, such a wish arises: “O that we were not subject to the results of our evil kamma. O may the results of our evil kamma not catch up with us.” But that cannot be obtained by wishing for it, and not to get what one wishes for is suffering.

As the Buddha declares in the *pāṭibhoga sutta* (AN 4.182), that just as for what is liable to death, there is neither a samana nor brahmana

nor Deva nor Mara nor Brahma nor anyone in the world who can guarantee that it will not die, so too for those evil kamma which are defiling, renewing a being, dreadful, ripening in suffering, bound up with future birth, old age and death, neither a samana nor brahmana nor Deva nor Mara nor Brahma nor anyone in the world including proponents of *ahosikamma*, can guarantee that their results will not actualize.

As the Buddha declares in the *samsappaniya sutta* (AN 10.216):

Beings, O bhikkhus, are owners of their kamma, heirs of their kamma, born of their kamma, descendants of their kamma, have kamma as their refuge. Whatever kamma they do, whether good or evil, they are the inheritors of it.
–AN 10.216

Thus, once one incurs the debt of accumulated kamma, one cannot escape its inheritance. One remains the only owner of one's kamma born of greed, hatred or delusion until one eliminates it by feeling all its results with no residue remaining; or else if it is kamma born of non-greed, non-hatred or non-delusion, then one eliminates greed, hatred and delusion in order to cut that kamma off at the root, make it like a palm stump, obliterate it so that it is no longer subject to future arising. The Buddha does not declare any other means of settling the debt of accumulated kamma.

Given that evil kamma accumulated in past lives cannot be escaped by any one in the world even though proponents of *ahosikamma* may wish otherwise, and that without experiencing the results of all kamma accumulated in past lives, the attainment of arahantship is not possible, how should the meaning of the Buddha's definition of the cessation of kamma be understood?

Since it is not possible to make an end of suffering and become an arahant without first making the breakthrough to the four noble truths to become a *sotāpanna* (see *kūṭāgāra sutta* SN 56.44), we first address the question as to whether the termination of accumulated past kamma happens only prior to the attainment of arahantship or are some of the accumulated past kamma required to undergo termination prior to the attainment of *sotāpanna* as well.

In the *nibbedhika sutta* (AN 6.63), the Buddha defines the diversity of *āsava* and the diversity of kamma to be equivalent as follows:

And what, O bhikkhus, is the diversity of asavas? There are, O bhikkhus, asavas leading to hell; there are asavas leading to the animal womb; there are asavas leading to the realm of ghosts; there are asavas leading to the world of human beings; there are asavas leading to the deva world. This, O bhikkhus, is called the diversity of asavas.

And what, O bhikkhus, is the diversity of kamma? There is, O bhikkhus, kamma to be experienced in hell; there is kamma to be experienced in the animal womb; there is kamma to be experienced in the realm of ghosts; there is kamma to be experienced in the world of human beings; there is kamma to be experienced in the deva world. This, O bhikkhus, is called the diversity of kamma.

–AN 6.63

In the *sabbāsava sutta* (MN 2), the Buddha says that there are *āsavas* to be abandoned by seeing the four noble truths:

It is from knowing, O bhikkhus, from seeing, that the extinction of the asavas come to be, I say, not from unknowing, not from unseeing. But knowing what, O bhikkhus, seeing what, does the extinction of the asavas come to be? Attention to the root-source and attention to the non-root-source. From attending to the non-root-source, O bhikkhus, unarisen asavas arise and arisen asavas increase. But from attending to the root-source, O bhikkhus, unarisen asavas do not arise and arisen asavas get abandoned...

He attends to the root-source thus: “This is suffering”; he attends to the root-source thus: “This is the origination of suffering”; he attends to the root-source thus: “This is the cessation of suffering”; he attends to the root-source thus: “This is the path leading to the cessation of suffering.” Of him attending to the root-source thus, three fetters get abandoned: the self-affirmation view, doubt, strong hold on virtue and practices. These, O bhikkhus, are called the asavas to be abandoned by seeing.

–MN 2

From this *sutta*, we know that along with the three fetters that get abandoned by the *sotāpanna*, the āsavas leading to hell, the āsavas leading to the animal womb, and the āsavas leading to the realm of ghosts, also go to extinction. Thus, the termination through feeling the results of intentional kamma accumulated in past lives to be experienced in hell, in the animal womb or in the realm of ghosts must precede the attainment of *sotāpanna*.

This is stated in terms of lust, hatred and delusion in the *appahāya sutta* (AN 6.89) as follows:

Without having abandoned six dhammas, O bhikkhus, one is incapable of realizing accomplishment in view. Which six?

Self-affirmation view, doubt, strong hold on virtue and practices, lust leading to the lower worlds, hatred leading to the lower worlds, delusion leading to the lower worlds.

Without having abandoned these six dhammas, O bhikkhus, one is incapable of realizing accomplishment in view.

Having abandoned six dhammas, O bhikkhus, one is capable of realizing accomplishment in view. Which six?

Self-affirmation view, doubt, strong hold on virtue and practices, lust leading to the lower worlds, hatred leading to the lower worlds, delusion leading to the lower worlds.

Having abandoned these six dhammas, O bhikkhus, one is capable of realizing accomplishment in view.

—AN 6.89

The one accomplished in view is the *sotāpanna*. This is just restating what has been pointed out regarding the *sabbasava sutta* (MN 2), that it is impossible to realize the fruit of stream entry without eliminating the asavas born of lust leading to the lower worlds, the asavas born of hatred leading to the lower worlds, the āsavas born of delusion leading to the lower worlds. These asavas are also called the asavas which are defiling, renewing a being, dreadful, ripening in suffering, bound up with future birth, old age and death (see *mahāsaccaka sutta* MN 36).

This is nicely summarized in the venerable *samitigutta theragāthā*

verse (Tha 81) as follows:

Whatever evil [kamma] I have done,
in previous other births;
that is to be felt right here,
no other place exists for it.

–Tha 81

In the *kamma sutta* (Ud 3.1) we get the following account illustrating this as well:

Thus was heard by me. At one time the Auspicious One was dwelling at Savatthi in Jeta's Grove, Anathapindika's Park. On that occasion a certain bhikkhu was sitting not far from the Auspicious One, having crossed his legs, having directed his body straight, having established mindfulness on the entire field of perception [internally], he was forbearing feelings borne of past kamma results that are painful, piercing, sharp, being mindful and contemplative, without distress.

The Auspicious One saw that bhikkhu sitting not far, having crossed his legs, having directed his body straight, having established mindfulness on the entire field of perception [internally], forbearing feelings borne of past kamma results that are painful, piercing, sharp, being mindful and contemplative, without distress.

Then the Auspicious One, having understood the significance of this, uttered this inspired utterance:

For the bhikkhu who is shaking off the dust of
past kamma,
the abandoning of all kamma;
For one like that, disowning, unmoved,
There is no ambition to chitchat with people.

–Ud 3.1

Another example of the *sotāpanna*'s depletion of kamma leading

to the lower worlds is summarized in the following verses that ends the *nidāna sutta* (AN 3.34):

“Whatever kamma that was done,
born of greed, hatred and delusion,
by a person not knowing [noble knowledge];
whether little or much,
that is to be felt right here;
other ground for it does not exist.

From that the wise bhikkhu,
giving rise to noble knowledge;
abandons all bad destinations,
born of greed, hatred and also delusion.

–AN 3.34

Once all kamma accumulated in past lives to be experienced in hell, the animal womb or the realm of ghosts are terminated through feeling their results, it becomes impossible for the *sotāpanna* to create new bodily, verbal and mental kamma to be experienced in the lower worlds as stated in the *abhabba sutta* (AN 6.91):

O bhikkhus, the individual accomplished in view is unable to give rise to these six dhammas. Which six?

Self-affirmation view, doubt, strong hold on virtue and practices, lust leading to the lower worlds, hatred leading to the lower worlds, delusion leading to the lower worlds.

These, O bhikkhus, are the six dhammas which an individual accomplished in view is unable to give rise to.

–AN 6.91

In the *saḷāyatanavibhaṅga sutta* (MN 137), the Dhamma-deaf puthujjana is contrasted with the *sotāpanna* as one who has not conquered the results (*vipāka*) [of evil kamma], being blind to their danger (*avipākajinassa anādīnavadassāvino assutavato puthujjanassa*). The Buddha gives a great simile for the suffering that the *sotāpanna* eliminates, in the *nakhasikhā sutta* (SN 13.1) as follows:

Then the Auspicious One, having put a small soil on the tip of his fingernail, addressed the bhikkhus: “So what do you think, O bhikkhus, which is more? This small soil put on the tip of a fingernail by me, or this great earth?”

“This, O Bhante, is clearly more, namely the great earth. This is a trifle, insignificant, this small soil the Auspicious One has put on the tip of his fingernail. In comparison to the great earth, this small soil the Auspicious One has put on the tip of his fingernail does not even count, it does not even come close to comparison, it does not even approach part of a fraction.”

It is just so, O bhikkhus, for the noble disciple, for the one accomplished in view. For the individual who has made the breakthrough, just this is more, namely, the suffering that is completely extincted, exhausted, [while the suffering] left over is insignificant. In comparison with the former stock of suffering that is completely extincted, exhausted, this does not even count, it does not even come close to comparison, it does not even approach part of a fraction, namely, the seven lives at most [remaining].

“Thus, O bhikkhus, is the great benefit of making the breakthrough to the Dhamma, thus is the great benefit of acquiring the Dhamma eye.”

–SN 13.1

Thus, it is clear that the termination by feeling the results of intentional kamma accumulated in past lives to be experienced in hell, in the animal womb or in the realm of ghosts precedes the attainment of *sotāpanna*. Once the *sotāpanna* becomes an *ānāgāmī*, then all intentional kamma accumulated in the present life to be experienced in hell, the animal womb or the realm of ghosts are also to be felt in this very life before death without residue remaining, since for the *ānāgāmī* who owns that kamma, there is no longer any where else existing for experiencing their results.

In light of the Buddha’s definition of the cessation of kamma being “that which touches liberation through the cessation of bodily, verbal and mental action,” and kamma is defined as intention which has contact as its origin (see the *nibbedhika sutta*, AN 6.63), the cessation of contact is that which touches liberation through the cessation of

bodily, verbal and mental action.

In the *kalahavivāda sutta* (Snp 4.11), the Buddha is asked about how one abides in the cessation of contact where “touches don’t touch”. He answers that it is for one who abides in such a way that form does not come to be, that “touches don’t touch” (*rūpe vibhūte na phusanti phassā*).

What is the source of contact in the world,
and also from where [comes] possessiveness?
When what is not does mine-ness not exist?
From the unbeing of what do touches not touch?

On account of name-and-form, there is contact.
Possessiveness springs from desire,
desire not being, mine-ness does not come to be.
From the unbeing of form, touches don’t touch.

How has one attained to the unbeing of form,
or even pleasure and pain, how do they unbecome?
Do declare this to me how they unbecome,
let us know that, thus was my thought.

Not percipient of perception, not percipient of
abnormal perception,
also not non-percipient, not devoid of being per-
cipient;
for one attained thus, there is the unbeing of form,
because subjective elaborations have perception
as their source.

–Snp 4.11

The *mahāsaḷāyatanika sutta*, (MN 149) describes how all accumulated five appropriable khandhas go to depletion for the attainment of arahantship by one who abides in such a way that there is the unbeing of form:

But O bhikkhus, one who knows and sees the eye as it has
come to be, one who knows and sees forms as they have

come to be, one who knows and sees eye-consciousness as it has come to be, one who knows and sees eye-contact as it has come to be, and this feeling which arises in dependence on eye-contact, whether pleasant or painful or neither-painful-nor-pleasant, that too one who knows and sees it as it has come to be, is not tainted in the eye, is not tainted in forms, is not tainted in eye-consciousness, is not tainted in eye-contact, and this feeling which arises in dependence on eye-contact, whether pleasant or painful or neither-painful-nor-pleasant, that too he is not tainted in it.

And for he who abides untainted, unattached, mindful, seeing in accordance with disadvantage, his five appropriable khandhas go to depletion for future [being]; and his thirsting—the renewer of being, accompanied by lusting after delight, delighting now here now there—is abandoned. His bodily stresses are abandoned, his mental stresses are abandoned, his bodily torments are abandoned, his mental torments are abandoned, his bodily fevers are abandoned, his mental fevers are abandoned, and he experiences bodily and mental pleasure.

He who has come to be of such view, that is his right view. He who has come to be of such thought, that is his right thought. He who has come to be of such effort, that is his right effort. He who has come to be of such mindfulness, that is his right mindfulness. He who has come to be of such samadhi, that is his right samadhi. But his bodily actions, verbal actions and livelihood are well purified just earlier. Thus, of him, this noble eight-fold path goes to full maturation by enculturation. From his maturation of the noble eight-fold path, the four establishments of mindfulness also go to full maturation by enculturation. The four right strivings also go to full maturation by enculturation. The four bases for psychic powers also go to full maturation by enculturation. The five faculties also go to full maturation by enculturation. The five powers also go to full maturation by enculturation. The seven awakening factors also go to full maturation by enculturation.

Of him these two dhammas turn yoked together: *samatha* and *vipassana*. He comprehensively knows by supreme knowledge those dhammas that should be comprehensively

known by supreme knowledge. He abandons by supreme knowledge those dhammas that should be abandoned by supreme knowledge. He brings into being by supreme knowledge those dhammas that should be brought into being by supreme knowledge. He realizes by supreme knowledge those dhammas that should be realized by supreme knowledge.

And what, O bhikkhus, are the dhammas that should be comprehensively known by supreme knowledge? It should be said, the five appropriable *khandhas*. That is: the form appropriable *khandha*, the feeling appropriable *khandha*, the perception appropriable *khandha*, the sankharas appropriable *khandha*, the consciousness appropriable *khandha*. These are the dhammas that should be comprehensively known by supreme knowledge.

And what, O bhikkhus, are the dhammas that should be abandoned by supreme knowledge? Ignorance and thirsting for being. These are the dhammas that should be abandoned by supreme knowledge.

And what, O bhikkhus, are the dhammas that should be brought into being by supreme knowledge? *Samatha* and *vipassana*. These are the dhammas that should be brought into being by supreme knowledge.

And what, O bhikkhus, are the dhammas that should be realized by supreme knowledge? Noble knowledge and liberation. These are the dhammas that should be realized by supreme knowledge.

—MN 149

Same is said about the five remaining faculties.

When the *sekha* abides knowing and seeing the eye, forms, eye consciousness, eye contact and the feeling born of eye contact as they have come to be, this is called knowledge and vision [of dhammas] as they have come to be (*yathābhūtañāṇadassana*), as explained in the *upanissa sutta* (SN 12.23). It is an abiding where the five faculties, the five powers, the seven factors of awakening or the noble eight-fold path is enculturated in dependence on seclusion, in dependence on fading away, in dependence on cessation, maturing in relinquishment. It is said to be an abiding in an abundant, exalted, immeasurable

samadhi, free from affliction in the *khaya sutta* (SN 46.26). For the *sekha* abiding in such an immeasurable samadhi, measurable accumulated kamma cannot persist, and have to be felt to bring about their extinction as explained in the *karajakāya sutta* (AN 10.219):

He wisely understands thus: “In the past, this mind of mine was measureable and undeveloped. However at present, this mind of mine is immeasurable and well developed. Any measureable kamma done will not remain there, will not persist there.”

–AN 10.219

As the Buddha makes it clear in the *mahāsaḷāyatanika sutta*, one’s thirsting also goes to extinction. With the extinction of thirsting, all kamma accumulated in past lives also go to extinction as described in the *khaya sutta* (SN 46.26):

“Here, O Udayi, a bhikkhu enculturates the mindfulness awakening factor in dependence on seclusion, in dependence on fading away, in dependence on cessation, maturing in relinquishment, abundant, exalted, immeasurable, free from affliction. For him enculturating the mindfulness awakening factor in dependence on seclusion, in dependence on fading away, in dependence on cessation, maturing in relinquishment, abundant, exalted, immeasurable, free from affliction, there is the abandoning of thirsting. With the abandoning of thirsting, there is the abandoning of kamma. With the abandoning of kamma, there is the abandoning of suffering. Thus, O Udayi, from the extinction of thirsting comes the extinction of kamma. From the extinction of kamma comes the extinction of suffering.”

–SN 46.26

Same is said about the six remaining awakening factors.

This is how the extinction of intentional kamma accumulated in past lives come about to make the attainment of arahantship possible.

2.2 Cessation of New Kamma

Given that termination through feeling the results of intentional kamma accumulated in past lives precedes the attainment of arahantship, what about the results of the intentional kamma accumulated in the present life? Does the arahant have to feel the results of all the intentional kamma accumulated in the present life as well or can the arahant escape their results?

As we have noted from the *nidāna sutta* (AN 3.34), all the intentional kamma accumulated with non-greed, non-hatred and non-delusion as source get abandoned when greed, hatred and delusion are eliminated. The Buddha gives a very illustrative simile as follows:

Just as, O bhikkhus, that there are seeds that are unbroken, unspoiled, undamaged by wind and sun, fertile, well kept. A man would burn them in a fire. Having burnt it in a fire, he would make them ashes. Having made them ashes, he would winnow them in a strong wind or he would cause them to be carried away in a swift flowing river. Thus, O bhikkhus, those seeds would be cut off at the root, made like palm stump, obliterated so that they are no longer subject to future arising.

So too, O bhikkhus, whatever kamma, is fashioned by non-greed, non-hatred or non-delusion, born of non-greed, non-hatred or non-delusion, with non-greed, non-hatred or non-delusion as its source, with non-greed, non-hatred or non-delusion as its origin, that kamma is abandoned when greed, hatred and delusion are eliminated. It is cut off at the root, made like palm stump, obliterated so that it is no longer subject to future arising.

—AN 3.34

This type of kamma is also described as the neither dark nor bright kamma with neither dark nor bright results which leads to the cessation of kamma (see *kamma sutta* AN 4.233). So once it serves its purpose of eliminating greed, hatred and delusion, which is also the cessation of kamma, then it is no longer needed and gets abandoned, since it neither leads to dark nor bright results.

In brief, the debt of accumulated kamma, whether born of greed, hatred and delusion or born of non-greed, non-hatred and non-delusion, are only paid off by feeling their results. Once greed, hatred and delusion are brought to extinction, all accumulated kamma born of non-greed, non-hatred and non-delusion also goes to extinction, leaving only the debt of kamma accumulated in the present life born of greed, hatred and delusion to be paid off by the arahant. As the dhammapada verses 127 states, "a place in the world does not exists, where staying one could be released from evil kamma", not even an arahant. The *lonaphala sutta* (AN 3.100) explains how all evil kamma accumulated in the present life come to be felt in this very life by the arahant without any residue remaining as follows:

Whoever, O bhikkhus, might say thus: "In which ever way that a person creates a kamma, in just that way he experiences." That being so, O bhikkhus, there is not the living the life of purity and an opportunity for rightly making an end of suffering is not evident.

But whoever, O bhikkhus, might say thus: "In which ever way to be felt that a person creates a kamma, in just that way he feels the results." That being so, O bhikkhus, there is the living the life of purity and an opportunity for rightly making an end of suffering is evident.

Here, O bhikkhus, for a certain person, even a trifling measure of evil kamma done leads him to hell. However here, O bhikkhus, for a certain person, that same trifling measure of evil kamma done is to be felt in this life without even a tiny [residual] to be seen, what [to speak of] very much [residual].

For what kind of person, O bhikkhus, does even a trifling measure of evil kamma done lead him to hell?

Here, O bhikkhus, a certain person is undeveloped in body, undeveloped in virtue, undeveloped in mind, and undeveloped in wisdom. He is inconsequential, depraved, and dwells in suffering over insignificant [matters]. For this kind of person, O bhikkhus, even a trifling measure of evil kamma done lead him to hell?

For what kind of person, O bhikkhus, does that same trifling measure of evil kamma done is to be felt in this life without

even a tiny [residual] to be seen, what [to speak of] very much [residual].

Here, O bhikkhus, a certain person is developed in body, developed in virtue, developed in mind, and developed in wisdom. He is influential, magnanimous, and dwells in immeasurable [samadhi]. For this kind of person, that same trifling measure of evil kamma done is to be felt in this life without even a tiny [residual] to be seen, what [to speak of] very much [residual].

“Just as, O bhikkhus, a salt crystal were to be dropped in a small cup of water. So what do you think, O bhikkhus, would such a salt crystal make the small cup of water salty and undrinkable?”

Yes, Bhante.

What is the reason for that?

Because, O Bhante, however much water there is in such a small cup, such a salt crystal would make that water salty and undrinkable.”

“Just as, O bhikkhus, a salt crystal were to be dropped in the river Ganges. So what do you think, O bhikkhus, would such a salt crystal make the river Ganges salty and undrinkable?”

Certainly not, Bhante.

What is the reason for that?

“Because, O Bhante, the river Ganges is an expansive body of water, such a salt crystal would certainly not make that water salty and undrinkable.”

So too, O bhikkhus, here for a certain person, even a trifling measure of evil kamma done leads him to hell. However here, O bhikkhus, for a certain person, that same trifling measure of evil kamma done is to be felt in this life without even a tiny [residual] to be seen, what [to speak of] very much [residual].

—AN 3.100

The person who is developed in body, developed in virtue, developed in mind, and developed in wisdom is the arahant. However, as

explained with reference to the *nigaṇṭha sutta* (see Section 2.3), the one accomplished in virtue (a stream enterer or once-returner) and the one accomplished in *samādhi* (the non-returner) also have access to an immeasurable *samādhi* which depletes accumulated kamma.

This is similar to the process of eliminating kamma accumulated in the present life by the noble disciple entering upon and abiding in a mundane immeasurable abiding such as the *metta* liberation of mind (*mettāceto vimutti*) or any of the other *brahmavihara* attainments where measurable kamma accumulated in the present life cannot persist and have to be felt and brought to extinction as in the *sankhadama sutta* (SN 42.8):

The noble disciple, O village chief, thus rid of covetousness, rid of ill-will, unconfused, mindful and contemplative, with a mind imbued with metta, dwells pervading one direction, likewise the second direction, likewise the third direction, likewise the fourth direction, above, below, around, to all beings in the entire world he dwells pervading with a mind imbued with metta, abundant, exalted, immeasurable, and free from enmity and ill-will. Just as, O village chief, a powerful conch shell blower would easily, without difficulty, convey [the sound of his conch shell] in the four directions, just so, O village chief, with the liberation of mind by metta thus enculturated, thus made abundant, any measureable kamma done will not remain there, will not persist there.

—SN 42.8

A good example of how even an arahant cannot escape feeling the results of evil kamma done in the present life to bring about their extinction is given in the *angulimāla sutta* (MN 86). Angulamala had killed many people prior to his encounter with the Buddha. He acquired confidence in the Buddha upon meeting him and soon after gaining bhikkhu ordination under the Buddha, he attained the noble birth of stream entry. The following is an account of the venerable Angulimala as an arahant experiencing the results of having killed many people during his life prior to encountering the Buddha:

Then in the morning, the venerable Angulimala, having

dressed, having taken bowl and outer robe, entered Savatthi for alms food. At that time, some threw stones that landed on the venerable Angulimala's body, others threw sticks that landed on the venerable Angulimala's body, others also threw potsherd that landed on the venerable Angulimala's body. So then the venerable Angulimala, with a broken bowl, with his head cut with blood dripping, with his outer robe torn apart, visited with the Auspicious One. The Auspicious One saw the venerable Angulimala approaching from afar. Having seen, he said this to the venerable Angulimala: "You bear it, O Brahmin. You bear it, O Brahmin. You, O Brahmin, are experiencing the results of kamma in this very life which, were it to ripen in hell, you would have roasted for many years, for many hundreds of years, for many thousands of years, for many hundreds of thousands of years."

–MN 86

Once all the present life accumulated evil kamma are also fully experienced through feeling their results, then the arahant is entirely free from all accumulated kamma, past or present (*kammanirodha*), and is said to be ownerless (*nirupadhī*), one who eats his food free from debt (*anaṇo bhuñjati bhojanam*) as explained in the *angulimāla sutta* verses (MN 86):

Having done much kamma [in this life],
of the kind leading to the lower worlds;
the results of that kamma has reached me now,
and so I eat my food free from debt.

–MN 86

2.3 Wearing Away Past Kamma Proper

There are some scholars who question the authenticity of the Buddha's declaration that without experiencing all intentional kamma accumulated in past lives, the attainment of arahantship is not possible. They claim that depletion of old kamma as a requirement for liberation from suffering is the doctrine of the Nigaṇṭhas and so the

Buddha could not have made such a declaration that supports the Nigaṇṭhas doctrine.

But in the *kesakambala sutta* (AN 3.137), the Buddha declares:

Just as, O bhikkhus, of all woven cloths, the hair blanket robe is declared the worst. Hair blanket, O bhikkhus, is cold when cold, hot when hot, ugly, foul smelling and uncomfortable. So too, O bhikkhus, of all the doctrines of the common samanas, the doctrine of Makkhali is declared the worst.

The empty man Makkhali, O bhikkhus, holds such doctrine, such view: “There is not kamma, there is not deed, there is not effort.”

Whichever arahants were of the past, O bhikkhus, rightly self-awakened ones, all those Auspicious Ones indeed [taught] the doctrine of kamma and the doctrine of deed and the doctrine of effort. Yet, this empty man Makkhali, O bhikkhus, contradicts them, [declaring]: “There is not kamma, there is not deed, there is not effort.”

Whichever arahants will be in the future, O bhikkhus, rightly self-awakened ones, all those Auspicious Ones too will indeed [teach] the doctrine of kamma and the doctrine of deed and the doctrine of effort. Yet, this empty man Makkhali, O bhikkhus, contradicts them too, [declaring]: “There is not kamma, there is not deed, there is not effort.”

At the present, O bhikkhus, I too, the arahant, the rightly self-awakened one, indeed [teach] the doctrine of kamma and the doctrine of deed and the doctrine of effort. Yet, this empty man Makkhali, O bhikkhus, contradicts me too, [declaring]: “There is not kamma, there is not deed, there is not effort.”

—AN 3.137

So it is clear that all Buddhas teach the doctrine of kamma in all its ramifications, including the role of kamma in liberation from suffering. The importance of kamma in the Buddha’s teachings is shown by the formulation of the four noble truths in terms of kamma as quoted in the *kammanirodha sutta* (SN 35.146). In the *nibbedhika sutta* (AN

6.63), the Buddha includes kamma as one of the six dhammas whose cessation is to be known as the penetrative life of purity. Also as stated in the *khaya sutta* (SN 46.26), the extinction of suffering comes about in dependence on the extinction of kamma.

So if the depletion of the intentional kamma accumulated in past lives is such a gating item for the attainment of arahantship, why does the Buddha criticize the Niganthas for making the depletion of kamma the goal of their teachings for bringing about the ending of suffering?

Since the Buddha says he does not one-sidedly blame and criticize any ascetic who leads a rough life, let's look at what the Buddha criticized of the Niganthas teachings and what he did not criticize of their teachings.

The Nigaṇṭha's view on kamma is stated by the Buddha in the *devadaha sutta* (MN 101) as follows:

There are, O bhikkhus, some samanas and brahmanas who hold such doctrine, such view: "Whatever this individual person experiences, whether pleasure, pain or neither pain nor pleasure, all that is caused by what was done in the past. So by the termination of past kamma with exertion, and the non-doing of new kamma, [there is] no oozings into the future. From no oozings into the future comes the extinction of kamma. From the extinction of kamma comes the extinction of suffering. From the extinction of suffering comes the extinction of feeling. From the extinction of feeling, all suffering will be worn away." Thus, O bhikkhus, is the doctrine of the Niganthas.

—MN 101

Since the Niganthas teach the termination of kamma accumulated in past lives as a path to liberation from suffering, the fact that their practice does not allow any way of measuring their progress towards liberation from suffering means that they teach a path to that which they do not know, to that which they do not see. The Buddha compares this way of teaching to a file of blind men in the *tevijja sutta* (DN 13). The Buddha also criticizes the Niganthas for not knowing the abandoning of unwholesome dhammas and the taking

up of wholesome dhammas in this very life which he regards as a requirement for any path purporting to lead to the cessation of suffering.

But because, O friend Niganthas, you do not know: “Indeed, we were in the past. It is not the case that we were not.” You do not know: “Indeed we did evil kamma in the past. It is not the case that we did not.” You do not know: “We did such or such evil kamma in the past.” You do not know: “So much suffering has been worn away or so much suffering remains to be worn away, or certainly by the wearing away of so much suffering, all suffering will be worn away.” You do not know the abandoning of unwholesome dhammas and the taking up of wholesome dhammas in this very life. That being so, it would not be proper for the venerable Niganthas to declare: “Whatever this individual person experiences...”

–MN 101

In their defence, the Niganthas fall back on their faith in their teacher, Nigaṇṭha Nataputta, who they believe to be all knowing and all seeing as he claims. The Buddha points out to them that the underlying views that one places faith in could turn out to be either true or false in this very life:

When thus was said, O bhikkhus, I said this to those Niganthas: “These five dhammas, O friend Niganthas, has twofold results in this very life. Which five? Faith, preference, tradition, mode of reasoning and submission to view after reflection. These five dhammas, O friend Niganthas, has twofold results in this very life. Therein, for the venerable Niganthas, what faith is there in a Teacher [who speaks] about the past? What preference, what tradition, what mode of reasoning, what submission to view after reflection?” When I said thus, O bhikkhus, I did not see among the Niganthas any defence that accords with the Dhamma.

–MN 101

The Buddha also criticizes the Niganthas about the fact that they

are not able to confirm that suffering is worn away when they are engaging in their practice to wear away suffering is blameworthy. If they can get some relief from pain when they are engaging in intense exertion and striving, compared to when they are not engaging in intense exertion and striving, then they can gain some solace that the path they are treading leads to the cessation of pain and therefore has a chance of leading to the cessation of suffering. But since engaging in intense exertion and striving causes them pain and they only gain relief from that pain when they do not engage in intense exertion and striving, the Buddha points out that they are feeling just their own self-inflicted afflictions that are afflictive, painful, piercing, sharp feelings of the piercing [austerities] and only make such declarations out of ignorance, lack of knowledge and delusion.

If, O friend Niganthas, on the occasion, when for you there is intense exertion, intense striving, on that occasion, you do not feel afflictive, painful, piercing, sharp feelings of the piercing [austerities], but on the occasion when for you there is no intense exertion, no intense striving, on that occasion, you feel afflictive, painful, piercing, sharp feelings from the piercing [austerities], then it would be proper for the venerable Niganthas to declare: “Whatever this individual person experiences...

But because, O friend Niganthas, on the occasion, when for you there is intense exertion, intense striving, on that occasion, you feel afflictive, painful, piercing, sharp feelings of the piercing [austerities], yet on the occasion when for you there is no intense exertion, no intense striving, on that occasion, you do not feel afflictive, painful, piercing, sharp feelings of the piercing [austerities], you are feeling just your own self-inflicted afflictions that are afflictive, painful, piercing, sharp feelings of the piercing [austerities]. Out of ignorance, lack of knowledge and delusion, you declare: “Whatever this individual person experiences...

–MN 101

Note that this view of wearing away past accumulations is popular among some modern meditation techniques where the view is adapted to the wearing away of past accumulated stock of sankharas instead of the wearing away of past accumulated kamma. The practice is that one sits for long periods and look on with equanimity at the

resulting self-inflicted feelings as a means of wearing away old stocks of sankharas. In Nigaṇṭhā Nāṭaputta's method, one can also stand or squat or induce pain in other ways for long periods and look on with equanimity at the resulting self-inflicted feelings as a means of wearing away old kamma. Since such methods boil down to an attempt to induce the ripening of kamma or sankhara by exertion and striving, the Buddha criticizes such methods as fruitless strivings.

So we see that the Buddha agrees with the Niganthas on the need to wear away old kamma in order to make an end of suffering. He disagrees with the Niganthas about the cause of suffering, which the Niganthas attribute to what was done in the past. He also disagrees with the Niganthas about the proper practice for wearing away old kamma. As stated in the *mahakotthita sutta* (AN 9.13), inducing the ripening of kamma to wear them away by exertion and striving is not the purpose of the life of purity under the Auspicious One:

Then the venerable Mahakotthita visited with the venerable Sariputta. Upon arrival, he exchanged friendly greetings with the venerable Sariputta. Having exchanged friendly greetings and cordial talk, he sat down to one side. Having sat down to one side, the venerable Mahakotthita said this to the venerable Sariputta.

How about this, O friend, Sariputta, "Let whichever kamma is to be experienced in this life be experienced by me in the after-life." Is this the purpose for which the life of purity is lived under the Auspicious One?

Certainly not, O friend.

Then how about this, O friend, Sariputta, "Let whichever kamma is to be experienced in the after-life be experienced by me in this life." Is this the purpose for which the life of purity is lived under the Auspicious One?

Certainly not, O friend.

How about this, O friend, Sariputta, "Let whichever kamma is to be experienced as pleasant be experienced by me as painful." Is this the purpose for which the life of purity is lived under the Auspicious One?

Certainly not, O friend.

Then how about this, O friend, Sariputta, “Let whichever kamma is to be experienced as painful be experienced by me as pleasant.” Is this the purpose for which the life of purity is lived under the Auspicious One?

Certainly not, O friend.

How about this, O friend, Sariputta, “Let whichever kamma is to be experienced when ripened be experienced by me when unripened.” Is this the purpose for which the life of purity is lived under the Auspicious One?

Certainly not, O friend.

Then how about this, O friend, Sariputta, “Let whichever kamma is to be experienced when unripened be experienced by me when ripened.” Is this the purpose for which the life of purity is lived under the Auspicious One?

Certainly not, O friend.

How about this, O friend, Sariputta, “Let whichever kamma is to be experienced substantially be experienced by me slightly.” Is this the purpose for which the life of purity is lived under the Auspicious One?

Certainly not, O friend.

Then how about this, O friend, Sariputta, “Let whichever kamma is to be experienced slightly be experienced by me substantially.” Is this the purpose for which the life of purity is lived under the Auspicious One?

Certainly not, O friend.

How about this, O friend, Sariputta, “Let whichever kamma is to be experienced not be experienced by me.” Is this the purpose for which the life of purity is lived under the Auspicious One?

Certainly not, O friend.

Then how about this, O friend, Sariputta, “Let whichever kamma is not to be experienced be experienced by me.” Is this the purpose for which the life of purity is lived under the Auspicious One?

Certainly not, O friend.

“Now then, for what purpose, O friend, is the life of purity lived under the Auspicious One?”

“Indeed, O friend, it is for the knowledge, for the vision, for the attainment, for the realization, for the breakthrough, of that which is unknown, unseen, unattained, unrealized, unbroken through, that the life of purity is lived under the Auspicious One.”

“But what, O friend, is unknown, unseen, unattained, unrealized, unbroken through, for the sake of its knowledge, vision, attainment, realization, and breakthrough that the life of purity is lived under the Auspicious One?”

“This is suffering”, O friend, is unknown, unseen, unattained, unrealized, unbroken through. It is for the sake of its knowledge, vision, attainment, realization, and breakthrough that the life of purity is lived under the Auspicious One.”

“This is the origination of suffering”, O friend, is unknown, unseen, unattained, unrealized, unbroken through. It is for the sake of its knowledge, vision, attainment, realization, and breakthrough that the life of purity is lived under the Auspicious One.” “This is the cessation of suffering”, O friend, is unknown, unseen, unattained, unrealized, unbroken through. It is for the sake of its knowledge, vision, attainment, realization, and breakthrough that the life of purity is lived under the Auspicious One.” “This is the path leading to the cessation of suffering”, O friend, is unknown, unseen, unattained, unrealized, unbroken through. It is for the sake of its knowledge, vision, attainment, realization, and breakthrough that the life of purity is lived under the Auspicious One.”

Indeed, O friend, it is for the knowledge, for the vision, for the attainment, for the realization, for the breakthrough of this which is unknown, unseen, unattained, unrealized, unbroken through, that the life of purity is lived under the Auspicious One.”

–AN 9.13

The Buddha rather emphasizes making the breakthrough to the four noble truths to acquire the noble right view, as the attainment of the know-how for the proper wearing away of old kamma. This is made clear in the *mahācattārisaka sutta* (MN 117) as follows:

Therein, O bhikkhus, right view comes first. And how, O bhikkhus, does right view come first? “For one of right view, O bhikkhus, wrong view is worn away. And those numerous evil unwholesome dhammas that arise in dependence on wrong view are also worn away, and those numerous wholesome dhammas that arise in dependence on right view go to full maturation by enculturation.

For one of right thought.... For one of right speech.... For one of right action.... For one of right livelihood.... For one of right effort.... For one of right mindfulness.... For one of right samadhi.... For one of right knowledge....

For one of right liberation, O bhikkhus, wrong liberation is worn away. And those numerous evil unwholesome dhammas that arise in dependence on wrong liberation are also worn away, and those numerous wholesome dhammas that arise in dependence on right liberation go to full maturation by enculturation.”

—MN 117

In the *nigāṇṭha sutta* (AN 3.74), the venerable Ānanda explains to a disciple of the Niganthas the proper purification practice for terminating old kamma as follows:

There are these three wearing away purifications, O Abhaya, rightly declared by the Auspicious One who knows and sees, the arahant, the rightly self-awakened one, for the purification of beings, for the surmounting of sorrow and lamentation, for the subsiding of mental and physical suffering, for the attainment of the know-how, for the realization of nibbana.

What three? “Here, O Abhaya, a bhikkhu is virtuous. He dwells restrained by the restraint of the patimokkha, endowed with conduct and resort, seeing danger in the slightest faults. Having undertaken the training rules, he trains in them. He does not do any new kamma and eliminates the old kamma touch after touch. The wearing away is visible here and now, not involving time, inviting eye witness, leading onwards, to be personally experienced by the wise.”

That bhikkhu, O Abhaya, thus endowed with virtue, quite secluded from sense-desires, secluded from unwholesome dhammas, he enters upon and abides in the pleasure with happiness born of seclusion, with thinking and with pondering, the first jhana. From the subsiding of thinking and pondering, with the internal tranquilization and unification of mind, without thinking and pondering, he enters upon and abides in the pleasure with happiness born of samadhi, the second jhana. With the fading away of happiness, dwelling mindful and contemplative, he looks on with equanimity as he experiences pleasure in the body, of which the Noble Ones say: “The mindful one is he who dwells in pleasure with equanimity.” He enters upon and abides in the third jhana. From the abandoning of [physical] pleasure and pain, from the extinction of former mental pleasure and mental pain, he enters upon and abides in the utter purity of mindfulness and equanimity without pain, without pleasure, the fourth jhana. He does not do any new kamma and eliminates the old kamma touch after touch. The wearing away is visible here and now, not involving time, inviting eye witness, leading onwards, to be personally experienced by the wise.”

That bhikkhu, O Abhaya, thus endowed with virtue, thus endowed with samadhi, with the extinction of the asavas, having realized for himself with supreme knowledge, in this very life, the asava-free mind liberation, wisdom liberation, and having entered upon it, dwells in it. He does not do any new kamma and eliminates the old kamma touch after touch. The wearing away is visible here and now, not involving time, inviting eye witness, leading onwards, to be personally experienced by the wise.”

These are the three wearing away purifications, O Abhaya, rightly declared by the Auspicious One who knows and sees, the arahant, the rightly self-awakened one, for the purification of beings, for the surmounting of sorrow and lamentation, for the subsiding of mental and physical suffering, for the attainment of the know-how, for the realization of nibbana.

—AN 3.74

Note that old kamma has a double meaning in this *sutta*. Since the

eye, ear, nose, tongue, body and mind are defined as old kamma by the Buddha, bringing about the cessation of any of them is said to be the wearing away of old kamma by touching cessation with it touch after touch without interval (*ānantarika samādhī*). It is also said to be the wearing away of old accumulated kamma since this is an abiding in an immeasurable *samādhī* where measurable accumulated kamma cannot persist.

The bhikkhu endowed with virtue is a stream enterer or a once-returner (see *kīṭāgiri sutta* MN 70), who abides in an immeasurable *samādhī* experiencing the attainment of knowledge and vision by touching cessation with the eye (*dhamma cakḅhu*). Since no new kamma can be created with intention for forms as cause because the eye has ceased and perception of forms have faded away, thus it is said: “he does not create new kamma”. Since the eye is terminated by cessation and the eye is old kamma, it is said: “he terminates old kamma.” Because he continuously touches cessation with the eye without interval, it is said: “touch after touch.” Because this is an abiding in an immeasurable *samādhī* where measurable accumulated kamma cannot persist, accumulated kamma is worn away. This wearing away is visible here and now, not involving time, inviting eye witness, leading onwards, to be personally experienced by the wise.”

The bhikkhu endowed with *samādhī* is a non-returner (see *kīṭāgiri sutta* MN 70), who abides in an immeasurable *samādhī* using the jhanas (and possibly the four brahma viharas or the domain of infinite space, the domain of infinite consciousness, or the domain of nothingness) as the gateway for touching liberation through the cessation of bodily, verbal and mental actions (see *aṭṭhakanāgara sutta*, AN 11.16). Since no new kamma can be created with bodily intention, verbal intention or mental intention as cause because the body and mind have ceased, it is said: “he does not create new kamma.” Since the body and mind are terminated by cessation and the body and mind are old kamma, it is said: “he terminates old kamma.” Because he continuously touches cessation with the body and mind without interval, it is said: “touch after touch.” Because this is an abiding in an immeasurable *samādhī* where measurable accumulated kamma cannot persist, accumulated kamma is worn away. This wearing away is visible here and now, not involving time, inviting eye witness, leading onwards, to be personally experienced by the wise.”

The bhikkhu who, with the extinction of the asavas, having realized for himself with supreme knowledge, in this very life, the asava-free mind liberation, wisdom liberation, and having entered upon it, dwells in it is the arahant, who abides in an immeasurable *samādhī* where all the six sense domain ceases without remainder. Since the arahant is incapable of creating new kamma, it is said: “he does not create new kamma.” Since all six senses are terminated by cessation and the six senses are old kamma, it is said: “he terminates old kamma.” Because he continuously touches cessation with the six senses without interval, it is said: “touch after touch.” Because this is an abiding in an immeasurable *samādhī* where measurable accumulated kamma cannot persist, accumulated kamma is worn away. This wearing away is visible here and now, not involving time, inviting eye witness, leading onwards, to be personally experienced by the wise.”

How does this address the Buddha’s criticism of the Nigantha’s doctrine? Given that the Buddha’s doctrine is that whatever feeling an individual person experiences, whether pleasure, pain or neither-pain-nor-pleasure, all that is due to contact, the *sekha* in the immeasurable attainment of knowledge and vision is witnessing the cessation of the eye, the cessation of forms, the cessation of eye-consciousness, the cessation of eye-contact, the cessation of feelings born of eye-contact, whether pleasant or painful or neither-painful-nor-pleasant. In other words, he is experiencing the cessation of all five appropriable khandhas that arise with the eye as source, which is the cessation of suffering. He knows that the suffering that remains to be worn away are the same five appropriable khandhas that arise with ear-contact as source, with nose-contact as source, with tongue-contact as source, with body-contact as source and with mind-contact as source. He knows that once all old kamma (eye, ear, nose, tongue, body and mind) are worn away, all suffering are also worn away. He does not have to take it on faith in the Buddha or anyone else. He is a witness of the Dhamma from what he has seen by himself, not from hearsay (*sakkhidhammamanītihamadassī*).

So the cessation of old kamma is the cessation of the eye, ear, nose, tongue, body and mind, as well as the total termination of all intentional kamma accumulated in past lives. The cessation of new kamma is the total extinction of any ground, any domain, any field, any possibility, any means by which measurable kamma accumulated in the present life can persist, since measurable kamma cannot

withstand being worn away by the arahant, who is said to dwell in the immeasurable. Thus from the *mahāassapura sutta* (MN 39), the arahant is called the bhikkhu who is [internally] bathed as follows:

And how, O bhikkhus, is a bhikkhu one who is [internally] bathed? He has washed off those evil unwholesome dhammas which are defiling, renewing a being, dreadful, ripening in suffering, bound up with future birth, old age and death.

–MN 39

The evil unwholesome dhammas which are defiling, renewing a being, dreadful, ripening in suffering, bound up with future birth, old age and death, include all evil accumulated kamma [also called āsavā] which are defiling, renewing a being, dreadful, ripening in suffering, bound up with future birth, old age and death.

The following verses extol the arahant's extinction of all kamma:

He is a Sambuddha, O brahmin, a transcender of all dhammas,
having attained all higher knowledges and powers,
endowed with Eye in all dhammas;
he has attained to the extinction of all kamma,
liberated through the extinction of all ownership.
–Snp 5.0

Exhausted is old [kamma], there is no new origination,
the mind is untainted in regard to future becoming;
the seeds extincted without desire for growth,
those wise ones are extinguished, just as this lamp.
–Snp 2.1

What could obstruct the dispeller,
the one divested of all kamma;
just like a big coin of gold from the Jambu River,
who is fit to blame him;
even the devas praise him,
by Brahma too, he is praised.
–AN 4.28